king of France, as Holy Roman Emperor. The Avignon papacy had become no more than the tool of the French crown; and John's decrees drove the last nail into the coffin of the papal monarchy, that theory placing all popes above any law.

"To comply with these teachings [of John XXII] . . . is none other than to allow the root of all governments to be cut up," wrote the Italian scholar Marsilius of Padua, in his 1324 treatise *Defensor Pacis*. "He . . . harbors no other design than to acquire for himself the ability to overthrow, at his own pleasure, the power of all governments, and hence to cast them into slavery to himself." But *Defensor Pacis* went far, far beyond a simple condemnation of John XXII. Just a few years earlier, the exiled poet Dante Alighieri had published a sharp rejection of the pope's right to confer the title of Holy Roman Emperor; arguing from scripture, from history, and from reason, Dante insisted that the Church had never been given authority over any earthly kingdom, and so could not bestow on any man a power that it did not own.

> Before Pilate, Christ disclaimed any ruling power of a temporal kind, saying, "My kingdom is not of this world." . . . This must not be understood to imply that Christ, who is God, is not Lord of the temporal kingdom . . . but rather to mean that, as exemplar of the Church, He had not charge of this kingdom.[5]

Marsilius, who had been serving as Louis of Bavaria's personal physician, agreed with Dante; Christ "did not come into the world to reign with temporal government or dominion," and the bishops of Rome had claimed this power through a "perverted inclination" for power. But then he went even further. The pope was not the head of the empire; neither was he the head of the Church itself. "He is no more the vicar of God than is any other bishop, as we have often said and shown before," Marsilius concluded.[6]

His argument was detailed and complex, but hinged on one all-important assertion: The "true church" is not centered at Rome, made up of those whom the pope recognizes as Christians; the true church is made up of all who worship Christ, all over the world, in any place or community. This community—the *ecclesia*, the "invisible church"—is spiritual, not earthly. It is not bound by time or place, and so it cannot have an earthly, time-bound ruler. Christ, not Peter, is the Rock upon whom the church is built; it has no human master.[7]

Within a decade of each other, Dante and Marsilius had given written shape and an intellectual foundation to the impulse that had pushed the